

interview of the week

ASIF ALI ZARDARI

It's not often that a Pakistan politician sits down for an interview and refrains from what is a favourite topic—India-bashing. Asif Ali Zardari is the exception. The 52-year-old co-chairman of the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) spent much of a 90-minute interview with Editor PRABHU CHAWLA for Aaj Tak TV channel talking about completing Benazir Bhutto's unfinished task and the need for strengthening Indo-Pak relationship. Excerpts:

Q. How much has your life changed after Bibi's untimely death?

A. Not just my life has changed, but that of Pakistan and also of the world has changed. As long as she was around, I had no worries. She was there to take care of everything.

Q. You were in jail for almost 11 years. You both were fighting, Bibi from outside and you from behind the bars.

A. Yes, we were together in our fight. Even today, I feel she is very much around, in spirit.

Q. In my last interview with her, Bibi told me, "I know that my life is under threat but I'm going to Pakistan just for the sake of democracy. My biggest task will be to end military rule". She sacrificed her life to restore democracy in the country. But even six months after her death, military rule is not yet over.

A. Her sacrifice will not go waste. We are working towards restoring democracy. Military rule is there but it is not Pervez Musharraf who is holding any such post.

Q. People of Pakistan elected both the PML-N and the PPP with this hope. Both of you were for his removal. So why is it taking so much of time?

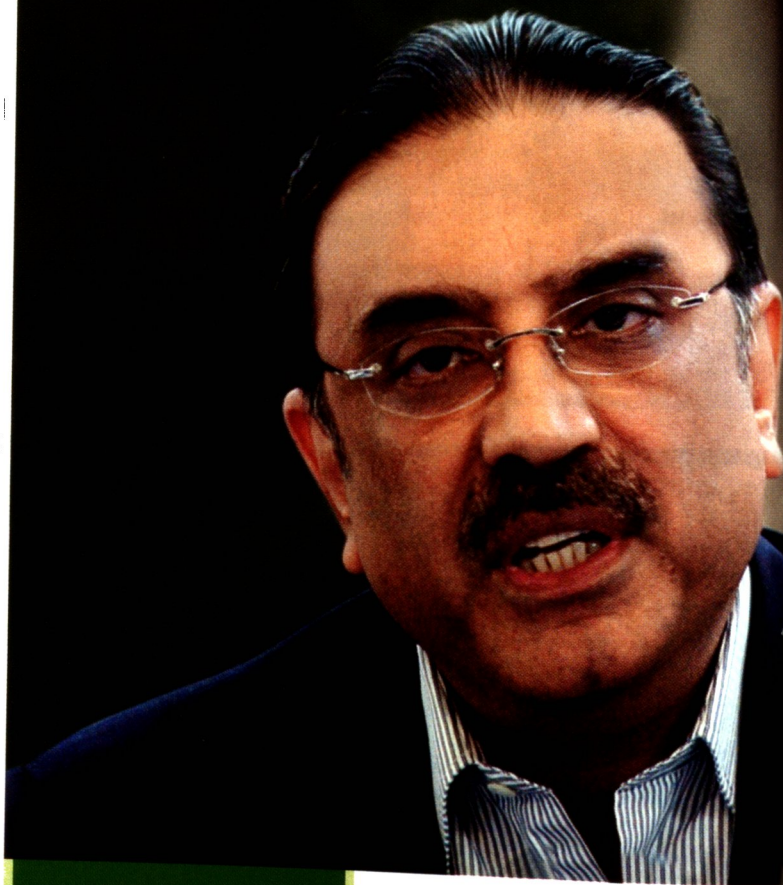
A. Unlike India, we never had a coalition government. This is the first-time for us. Both the parties have almost equal number of seats. Even if we combine together, we will still fall short of the required number to oust him. We don't even have the support of other parties.

Q. Have you set any time frame for Musharraf's ouster?

A. Politicians seldom stick to deadlines. But we will pack him off soon.

Q. You are the working president of the party though your son Bilawal is the chairman. Why so when you

"I DON'T REMOTE CONTROL THE GOVERNMENT"



"POLITICIANS DON'T STICK TO DEADLINES, BUT WE WILL PACK HIM (MUSHARRAF) OFF VERY SOON."

could have done it yourself?

A. We have chosen Bilawal because he is our future, he is our present. Our new slogan: *Bhutto ki tasveer Benazir, Benazir ki tasveer Bilawal* (Benazir is Bhutto's image and Bilawal is Benazir's). Bilawal is our future. I am just a trustee of Benazir's legacy.

Q. People say you are Pakistan's Sonia Gandhi. Like she controls the Government from 10, Janpath in Delhi you do the same from Bilawal